Making pens from scratch – part 2

In the second part of his pen series, **Walter Hall** makes the body and cap of a fountain pen

In the previous part of this article I made the section or core of a fountain pen. In this second part I shall show how I made the body and cap. In many ways this project bears comparison with an earlier article about making closed-end pens – see *Woodturning* 281 – and many of the techniques and mandrels used could be applied and used when making pens from scratch. The greatest differences are in the absence of brass tubes or any other kit components and the need to cut both internal and external threads to fit the components to the section and to one another.

Choice of materials is important, not all acrylics are suitable as I found when making the section, and while the body and cap components are not as small and delicate as the section ones, materials that are too brittle will not stand up to the drilling and thread cutting processes. Some close grained hardwoods will take threads fine enough for pen bodies especially if strengthened with cyanoacrylate but for the purposes of this article I chose to use a True Blood Kirinite blank from GPS Agencies having found in my tests for *Woodturning* 284 that this material would hold a fine thread.

Some turners may prefer to make a drawing before beginning work on their pen, but for this project I just had a simple design in my head and built up the shape as I went along. If you choose to work in this way do be aware that you may have to make changes and re-work components. For example, when initially shaping the grip of the section I made it too large a diameter and had to go back and reduce the size in order for the cap section to fit over it. Drawings and plans would preclude this sort of problem, but for me learning by my mistakes is part of the creative process.

EQUIPMENT AND MATERIALS USED

Beading & parting tool
Parting tool
Bandsaw
Scroll chuck
Digital calipers
6.5mm drill bit
Jacobs chuck
Spindle gouge
Digital Vernier caliper
Threaded mandrel
Razor saw
'True Blood' Kirinite blank
Medium cyanoacrylate
Imitation ebony rod
Abranet and Micro-Mesh abrasives
Farecla polishing compounds

WALTER HALL

Walter Hall is a woodturner who has specialised in making pens and pencils for more than 20 years. Based on the beautiful Northumberland coast in the UK, Walter sells his bespoke pens and pencils through local craft centres and via his website.

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PHOTOGRAPHS BY WALTER HALL

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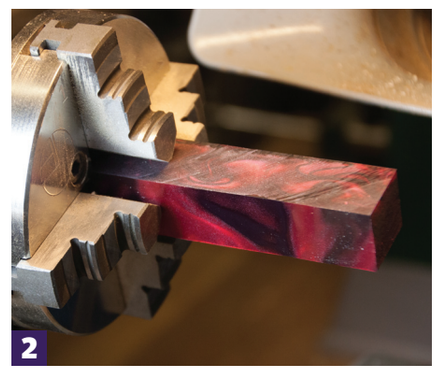
1 I began by lining up the blank against the section and ink converter and marking off the approximate length of the cap and body components. I will not be fitting a clip to this pen, but if you decide to do so then you may need to leave extra length on the cap to make a finial piece to retain the clip. I will look at fitting clips in a future article or project



2

2 After cutting the blank to length on the bandsaw I mounted the longer piece that will form the barrel of the pen into a scroll chuck fitted with a set of engineers' jaws. Pin jaws would also work for this or any small jaws capable of gripping the blank true to the axis of the lathe

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